

A woman has been prosecuted for illegally importing more than 62,000 kilograms of Thai food into Australia, for distribution on Sydney's black market.

The woman coordinated the importation of illegal pork products, insect-infested fresh fruit and vegetables, frog meat and raw prawns by misdeclaring them. The offending included product substitution and the presentation of false and misleading documents to evade biosecurity controls.

On 11 June, the Judge convicted her of 9 counts against the Biosecurity Act 2015 and she was sentenced to 24 months imprisonment to be served by way of an Intensive Corrections Order. The Offender was also ordered to serve 150 hours of Community Service.

A confidential source tipped the department off about the prolific amount of prohibited food from Thailand available on the black market in Sydney.

Operation Torch identified the woman, and the department immediately intervened to ensure the goods were seized and the biosecurity risk was mitigated.

Deputy Secretary of Biosecurity, Compliance and Operations, Justine Saunders emphasised that Australia's biosecurity rules and practices are among the strictest in the world.

"Individuals can face up to 10 years in jail and up to \$1.6 million in fines if they breach our biosecurity laws," Ms Saunders said.

"The importation of such a large amount of food from Thailand, some of it infested with live pests, presents numerous biosecurity risks to Australia.

"I would like to thank our highly trained biosecurity officers for intercepting the illegally imported food and those who investigated this matter.

"Australia is free from many of the pests, weeds and diseases that impact agricultural productivity and the environment in other parts of the world. Our biosecurity officers work tirelessly to keep these pests out.

"Illegal activity can undermine Australia's animal, plant and human health status and our excellent global reputation."

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/about/news/illegal-food-imports>